

James Boswell

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James Boswell (1740-1795) is best known as the biographer of Dr Samuel Johnson, but his life is fascinating on its own. He spent much time in Fleet Street, meeting Johnson and other leading literary figures. Boswell kept detailed diaries, recording his conversations, thoughts, and personal life, including his struggles with melancholy and his numerous affairs.

He studied at Edinburgh and Glasgow, briefly considered becoming a monk, and trained as a lawyer, practising in Edinburgh for over a decade while visiting London regularly. In 1769 he married his cousin Margaret, with whom he had seven children.

Boswell travelled with Johnson on the famous Hebrides tour in 1773, later publishing his gossipy, vivid account. He devoted his later years to writing *The Life of Samuel Johnson* (1791). Despite health problems and limited political success, Boswell's meticulous diaries survived through generations, eventually reaching Yale University, giving us an extraordinary view of 18th-century literary and social life.



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